



LAST-MILE CONNECTIVITY The Katra-Banihal section features the world's highest railway arch bridge on the Chenab river

SRINAGAR RAIL CONNECTIVITY

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Triumph of Engineering

The Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Railway Line in J&K is set to expedite trade and tourism

BY RICHAR SHARMA

► **IT TOOK 28** long years since construction work started for Srinagar to get connected by rail. The Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Railway Line (USBRL) in Jammu and Kashmir is set to boost economic prospects in the Valley by providing all-weather rail connectivity to the rest of the country round the year.

The ₹40,000-crore project has seen several delays since 1997. The route has some of the iconic bridges, including a first-of-its-kind cable-stayed bridge in the country, and will provide 13-hour Delhi-Srinagar rail connectivity at an economical rate. Trial runs were conducted at a speed of 110 kmph on the section passing through the scenic Himalayas.

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah called it a "historic milestone". He said the new rail division would bring administrative control closer to Jammu, reduce reliance on Firozpur, and create local job opportunities.

"This connectivity will boost trade and tourism. During winters, air travel becomes prohibitively expensive, with ticket prices reaching up to ₹25,000. Rail connectivity will ease the financial burden on travelers, enhance the transport of goods, and significantly benefit industries in the region," said Abdullah.

What took the longest time was the 111-km-long Katra-Banihal section, which is connected through around 97 km of tunnels and 7 km of bridges. The route also features the

world's highest railway arch bridge on the Chenab river. There are seven stations on the section and these station yards are constructed partly inside tunnels and on bridges due to space constraints. The entire section is also electrified.

Indian Railways has created a separate Jammu division and special funds will be allocated for further enhancing rail connectivity. The area used to fall under Firozpur rail division till recently.

The Jammu-Srinagar Vande Bharat Express has been specially designed for cold climates and is capable of operating at temperatures as low as -20°C. A dedicated snow removal train will ensure uninterrupted service. The driver's cabin features a heated windshield to prevent it from fogging up or freezing. Further, the train has heating elements in its plumbing and bio-toilets.

The connectivity is set to expedite trade, tourism, and other economic activities. Besides the Vande Bharat train, Indian Railways plans to extend several long-distance trains from that currently terminate in Jammu. With convenient and economical connectivity, a trip to paradise is not that far anymore. **BT**

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